

render them vessels of the grace of faith. In what sense Augustine and his audience may have thought of these calls as posing a 'moral obligation', as Dupont suggests (p. 199), might be worth further exploring.

What is also very interesting is the wide-ranging similarity between anti-Donatist and anti-Pelagian *sermones*. For example, both groups contain samples that emphasize the need for grace in the ongoing struggle with concupiscence, even after baptism, and the impossibility of a sinless life. Of course, these similarities have long been known for Augustine's other works and they are here merely confirmed. Dupont therefore warns to keep attempts at dating sermons on the basis of such elements alone 'to a minimum' (p. 202). Overall, he concludes, there is a high degree of continuity among all sermons, and in the present selection specifically also among the festal and the anti-Donatist sermons, both chronologically and thematically. Whether in non-polemical contexts, as in many of the festal sermons, or in the anti-Donatist sermons, Augustine's thinking on grace is ever present. At the centre of each sermon, however, is always the immediate audience, and the preacher is above all concerned, as Dupont closes, 'to teach the correct faith, to stress divine grace, and to exhort to an ethical life' (p. 203).

Thus this brief and compelling study is an excellent guide to the sermons discussed in it. It is also useful for the study of Augustine's sermons more generally and for the study of his doctrine of grace.

doi:10.1093/jts/flv049

Advance Access publication 26 May 2015

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Augustine's Theology of Preaching. By PETER T. SANLON. Pp. xxxii + 211. Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2014. ISBN 978 1 4514 8278 2 and 8760 2. Paper £16.99; e-book n.p.

WHILE the format of this book is largely given by its origins in a doctoral thesis, it is aimed primarily not at fellow academics or students (though the latter in particular may benefit from its clarity of argument and accessible prose style) but at those with a lively interest in preaching the Word of God. To judge by the preface and introduction, it is written in particular for those whose interest is informed by an evangelical protestant

faith, but its merit is by no means limited to this readership. The book serves its readers by illuminating for them the 'undergirding theological convictions which shaped Augustine's approach to the task of preaching' through study of his *Sermones ad populum* (p. xix), some 590 of which have come down to us.

Chapter 1 is entitled 'The Historical Context of Augustine's Preaching' and offers an extremely brief account (21 pages) of the North African ecclesial context and earlier Christian preaching. It may be helpful for newcomers to Augustine and early Christianity, but others will find it thin (Origen and his allegorical interpretation of the Old Testament is a significant omission, while the account of Ambrose's preaching says nothing of his hermeneutical debt to Basil and through Basil to Origen). Chapter 2, 'Pagan Oratory', offers snapshots of major figures in the pagan oratorical tradition: Gorgias, Plato, Cicero, Quintilian, and Apuleius. Scripture is introduced as the authority which replaces for Augustine Plato's reliance upon 'philosophical truth'. Christ is the teacher who speaks exteriorly through Scripture and interiorly within the believer's heart in the reception of Scripture. Sanlon holds that Augustine's 'immersion in scripture' together with his reflection on the 'inadequate anthropologies of Pelagianism and Stoicism' (p. 44) led to a new understanding of the heart rather than the mind or pure intellect as the focus of the preacher's ministry. The heart could be swayed by the temporal or narrative dimension of Scripture as Augustine invited listeners into the story where 'they could be forgetful of their prior self-interpretations' and their loves could be reordered (p. 45). For Sanlon, this means that 'Augustine's preaching brought an authority to bear upon listeners with an inner power which surpassed that available to secular rhetoric'.

In chapter 3 Sanlon summarizes Augustine's teaching in the *De doctrina christiana*. The summary is lucid if patchy (Tychonius' Rules are mentioned but not listed). The key insight is that the refocusing of human love on God as our ultimate good 'is made possible by the incarnated Christ revealing *temporally* that which was lost *inwardly*' (p. 62). Creation and Scripture are both structured around Christ, and our understanding of both depends on faith in him who reorders the knowing heart. The persuasive preacher is one whose own prayerful faith and thirst for God's gracious revelation rouse the listener to share the humble interrogation of Scripture. Sanlon has thus laid the ground for further exploration and definition in chapter 4 of 'interiority' and 'temporality' as the 'hermeneutical keys' needed to grasp the theological grounds of Augustine's

preaching. The pertinence of these keys is highlighted through brief consideration of three other readings of Augustine: by Coleen Hoffman Gowans, Paul Ricoeur, and Charles Taylor.

The next three chapters present a series of case studies, examining in turn the themes of riches, death and resurrection, and 'relationships' (between parents and children, masters and slaves, husbands and wives, and friends). Thus, in sermon 177 on avarice 'Augustine presents temporality so to impact the interiority of listeners. Riches are reframed and reordered in the light of Christian temporality, to develop a hunger for interior riches...' (p. 107). The readings are succinct, apposite, and engaging, as they reveal how 'Augustine's preaching' invites us 'to look beneath the surface, to explore the mystery of true value' which is otherwise obscure to us (p. 120). A brief final chapter recapitulates the main points and returns to their value for contemporary preachers. They may indeed gain much from this welcome book.

doi:10.1093/jts/flv128

Advance Access publication 18 September 2015

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Crisis Management in Late Antiquity (410–590 CE): A Survey of the Evidence from Episcopal Letters. By PAULINE ALLEN and BRONWEN NEIL. Pp. xiii + 284. (Supplements to *Vigiliae Christianae*, 121.) Leiden: Brill, 2013. ISBN 978 90 04 18577 7 and 25482 4. Hardback €109/\$141; e-book n.p.

TODAY'S scholars of Christian antiquity tend to discover just as much ecclesial practice and theological belief in their study of how early followers of Jesus lived and carried out their day-to-day routines as the more standard credal and doctrinal histories. For example, Helen Rhee and Peter Brown have both published important works on the understanding and use of money in late antique Christianity, Thomas Oden has put together *The Good Works Reader*, chronicling how believers sought to carry out the gospel mandate to love in very mundane ways, and other recent studies abound. Worthy of study alongside these important works is this dual-authored monograph by Pauline Allen and Bronwen Neil (both at Australian Catholic University), which complements them in two important ways.